

Defense Wins Championships? Analyzing the 2026 Chicago Cubs' Historic Fielding Season

By Nolan Bunn

"Offense sells tickets, defense wins championships." -Paul "Bear" Bryant, Alabama University Football Head Coach

Paul "Bear" Bryant coined that phrase when he was head coach of Alabama University football, and the phrase makes lots of sense for football. Defenses in football can directly stop their opponents from advancing the ball and can even steal possession back for their team. Many championships were won by the greatest defenses ever: the Steel Curtain, the Legion of Boom, and the '85 Bears all won Super Bowls in dominant fashion. 41 years later, another Chicago team is proving that same philosophy may apply to the baseball diamond.

Like their Windy City predecessors, the 2026 Chicago Cubs are having a historically great defensive season. More specifically, a historically great fielding season. This article aims to answer two questions: "How did the Cubs get here?" and "How much will fielding affect their playoff run?".

Part 1- How did the Cubs get here?

According to Baseball Savant, Fielding Run Value (FRV) metric "is Statcast's metric for capturing a player's measurable defensive performance by converting all of Statcast's individual defensive metrics from different scales onto the same run-based scale, which can then be read as a player being worth X runs above or Y runs below average." (Baseball Savant, 2026). FRV measures how many runs a fielder saves or costs his team through defense. Adding up a whole roster's FRV gives a team's FRV or how many runs they have stopped or allowed this season based only on fielding. The Cubs currently have a +51 FRV through July 29th (Baseball Savant, 2026), meaning they have stopped 51 runs from scoring through fielding. For context, the Diamondbacks, currently 2nd in FRV, have a +27 FRV (Baseball Savant, 2026). In comparison, the 2025 Blue Jays lead the majors in FRV with +45 runs. Chicago is 6 runs ahead of that mark with still two months of baseball left to play. Since 2018, when this statistic was introduced, the highest full season score is held by the 2018 Diamondbacks, +65 FRV (Baseball Savant, 2018). The Cubs are currently on pace for around a +77 FRV. Every comparison points to the same conclusion: the Cubs are on pace for the greatest defensive season in the Statcast Era.

One of the primary drivers of this incredible defensive season by the Cubs is Pete Crow-Armstrong. Their polarizing superstar centerfielder is having a historic season in his own right. His +22 FRV tops the MLB this year (Baseball Savant, 2026). FRV is broken down into specific categories such as range, arm, and double play ability. Pete Crow-Armstrong's +18 FRV through range (how much area he covers in the field) also is first in the MLB, while his +4 FRV through his arm is fourth in the MLB (Baseball Savant, 2026). His unique combination of speed, tracking ability, and arm strength is anchoring this dominant defense and setting him up for a historic season. He is on pace for a +33 FRV, which would beat Patrick Bailey's single-season

record +32 FRV (Baseball Savant, 2026). Crow-Armstrong's +22 FRV is still the 10th best defensive season since 2018, and he has only played around two-thirds of the season (Baseball Savant, 2026).

While Pete Crow-Armstrong's season is impressive, the Cubs find fielding strength in their depth. Crow-Armstrong is 4th in FRV contributed by throwing, but fellow outfielders Ian Happ and Seiya Suzuki are 3rd and 6th respectively (Baseball Savant, 2026). Half of the top 6 best arms this season come from Chicago's outfield. The infield is strong as well. Dansby Swanson and Nico Horner hold down the up-the-middle defense ranking 23rd and 31st in FRV in the MLB, with +7 FRV and +6 FRV respectively (Baseball Savant, 2026). The Cubs defensive depth goes all the way up and down their lineup. Even the Cubs' weakest defender, Scott Kingery, illustrates their remarkable depth. As a utility infielder Kingery accumulated -2 FRV in only six innings, while recent elite defensive teams like the 2025 Blue Jays still featured everyday liabilities such as George Springer (-8 FRV) and Bo Bichette (-10 FRV). (Baseball Savant, 2026). The Cubs are built around the best defensive talent in the league, several key defensive contributors around him and no defensive liabilities dragging them down. This rare mix could be setting them to be the greatest defensive team of the Statcast Era.

Part 2- How much will defense affect their playoff run?

As previously stated, the Cubs are on pace for around +77 FRV, a very impressive number, but across a 162-game season how much impact are they making? Dividing the Cubs' FRV by their innings fielded and multiplying that number by 9 creates a new metric, "Fielding Run Value per 9" (FRV/9) or how many runs a fielding team allows or saves through fielding each game. The 2026 Cubs have an FRV/9 of +0.477, a record-breaking year if it holds. Mapped out in Figure 1 is each top 3 defense since 2018 in FRV/9, as well as the 2026 Cubs.

Top 3 Defenses in FRV/9 each year

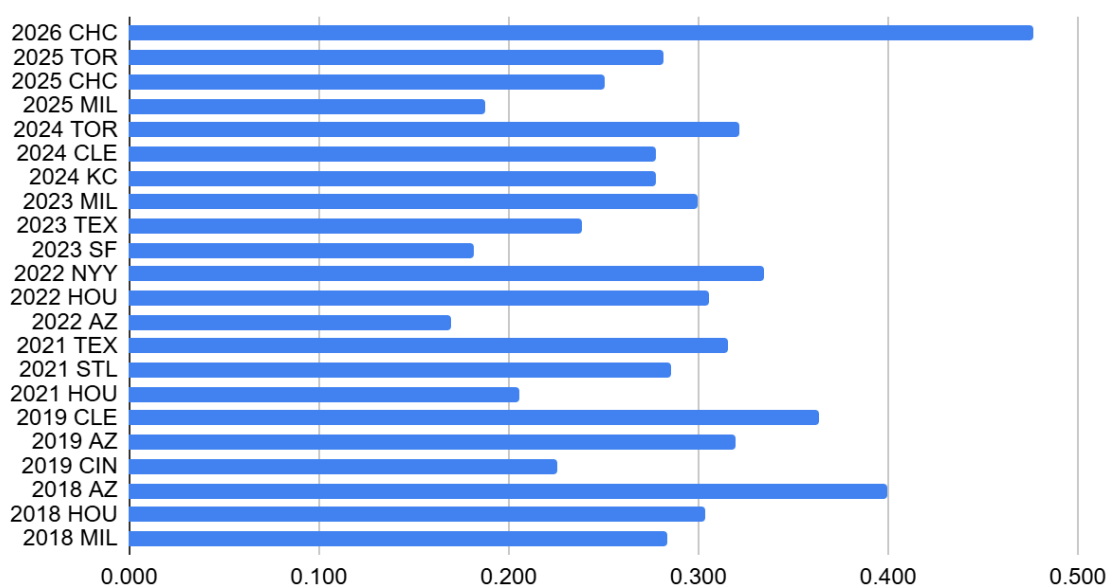


Figure 1. Every top 3 defense since 2018 in FRV/9 compared to the 2026 Cubs.

Even when compared to the most elite defenses, the Chicago Cubs are head and shoulders above the rest. The next best team in FRV/9 are the 2018 Arizona Diamondbacks who scored +0.4 FRV. No other team has reached higher than a +0.363 FRV. The Cubs' +0.477 mark means that they are removing nearly half a run from the scoreboard every game. Not only that, they save 19.25% more runs on a per-game basis than the next best team since 2018. The Cubs are saving nearly half a run a game consistently. That 0.477 runs saved is around the same difference as Cristopher Sanchez's 2.73 ERA versus Sean Burke's 3.19 ERA (Fangraphs, 2026). Sean Burke is having a great season, but he is not a Cy Young candidate like Cristopher Sanchez. The Cubs create that difference every single game, day in and day out.

Clearly, the Cubs' fielding ability is positively affecting their ability to win games, but can they turn it into a World Series? Among the top 3 fielding teams by FRV in each year since 2018 (excluding the shortened 2020 season), 13 of those 21 teams made the playoffs (Baseball-Reference, 2026). 4 of those teams have made the World Series. Two have won the Fall Classic. (Baseball-Reference, 2026). These great fielding teams can eliminate runs on balls in play, and the 2026 Cubs do it as well as anyone else, if not better. However, the truly great teams combine fielding with other good statistical contributions outside of when they are fielding. Great fielding teams transform into great overall teams when they have low HR/9, low BB/9 and high offensive runs scored. Low HR/9 and low BB/9 forces the opposition to score runs by putting balls in play, and high runs scored puts even more pressure on the opposition to break the wall of fielders. In essence, great fielding reaches its full potential if the fielders get to see a high amount of balls in play and the team still plays well on the batting half of the inning.

Consider the top defensive seasons by a team since 2018, the 2018 Diamondbacks, +65 FRV, and the 2022 Yankees, +54 FRV (Baseball Savant, 2026). The Diamondbacks went 82-80 and missed the playoffs, while the Yankees won 99 games and made the ALCS (Baseball-Reference, 2022). Even though the Diamondbacks were a better fielding team, their pitchers gave away too many runs from walks and home runs, which can not be defended. The Diamondbacks ranked 17th in BB/9, while the Yankees ranked 8th their year (Baseball-Reference, 2022). The Diamondbacks actually could control the long ball, ranking 9th in HR/9 (Baseball-Reference, 2018), unlike many great fielding teams who missed the playoffs. Examples include the 2024 Blue Jays (Best FRV in 2024 and finished 74-88), who ranked 29th in HR/9, and the 2021 Rangers (Best FRV in 2021 and finished 60-102), who ranked 27th in HR/9 (Baseball-Reference, 2024). Of the three complementary statistics, offensive run production is the most important.. This number is important for any team, but it will ensure that quality fielding does not go to waste. The successful Yankees team scored 807 runs, 2nd in the MLB, while the 2018 Diamondbacks scored 693 runs, 18th in the MLB (Baseball-Reference, 2022). HR/9, BB/9, and runs are vital statistics for any team, but they become especially important when considering great fielding teams. Pitchers giving up free runs with walks and home runs and a lineup that can not back up its production in the field minimizes the potential great fielding brings.

The good news for the Cubs is that they rank very well in two of these stats. Through July 29th, they have the 3rd best offense in the MLB and 8th best BB/9 (Baseball-Reference, 2026). They are minimizing base runners and defensive stars, like Pete Crow-Armstrong, can still swing the bat well. If the Cubs' incredible season turns south it will be through home runs allowed. Their pitching staff has allowed the 2nd most HR/9 in the MLB (Baseball-Reference, 2026). No matter how well this defense plays they can not stop a ball from leaving the yard.

Where does this leave the Cubs? They struggle with home runs, but are still filled with amazing fielders and have a great offense. No great fielding team is going to be number 1 in runs, BB/9 and HR/9 and no team is going to be last in all 3. To properly find teams to compare to Chicago, a "distance score", derived from the distance formula in mathematics, can be applied to identify comparable teams.

$$\sqrt{(Team\ X's\ FRV/9 - Cubs' FRV/9)^2 + (Team\ X's\ Runs\ Rank - Cubs' Runs Rank)^2 + (Team\ X's\ BB/9\ Rank - Cubs' BB/9 Rank)^2 + (Team\ X's\ HR/9\ Rank - Cubs' HR/9 Rank)^2}$$

Figure 2. Distance Score Equation

When entering that equation into the last 21 great defensive teams, two clear teams emerged. The 2025 Blue Jays, who lost to the Dodgers in the World Series, and the 2025 Cubs, who made it to the NLDS (Baseball-Reference, 2026) . Both of these teams were top 2 in FRV, carried top 5 offenses and did not walk their opponents (The Cubs had the best BB/9 figure in 2025), but allowed many home runs. After a dropoff in score, the third-most comparable team is the 2023 Rangers who utilized the 2nd most valuable defense in the MLB en route to a World Series victory. These teams and their characteristics, fielding, run-scoring, and struggling with allowing home runs, show that this currently composed Cubs team does have World Series potential.

The Cubs definitely can make a deep playoff run. They have a defensive superstar, quality defenders at every position and are not sacrificing offensive firepower. Are they a fluke though? Will there be more great teams with defense as a calling card? Yes, there will be more teams built like the Cubs. Rob Manfred has ushered a new ball-in-play era of the sport where defense and athleticism are crucial. In 2023, MLB instituted a ban on defensive shifts and created larger bases (MLB.com, 2023). Speed, defense, and athletes became a premium trait. Since 2023, 7 of the 9 (77.7%) top 3 defenses in FRV have made the postseason (Baseball Savant, 2025). From 2018 to 2022 (excluding 2020), 6 of the 12 (50%) top 3 defenses in FRV made the postseason (Baseball Savant, 2022). Now, more than ever in the past decade of baseball, Paul Bryant's "Defense wins championships" rings true. In today's game, championships are not just won with a bat, but also with defense and fielding and that is great news on the North Side of Chicago.

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